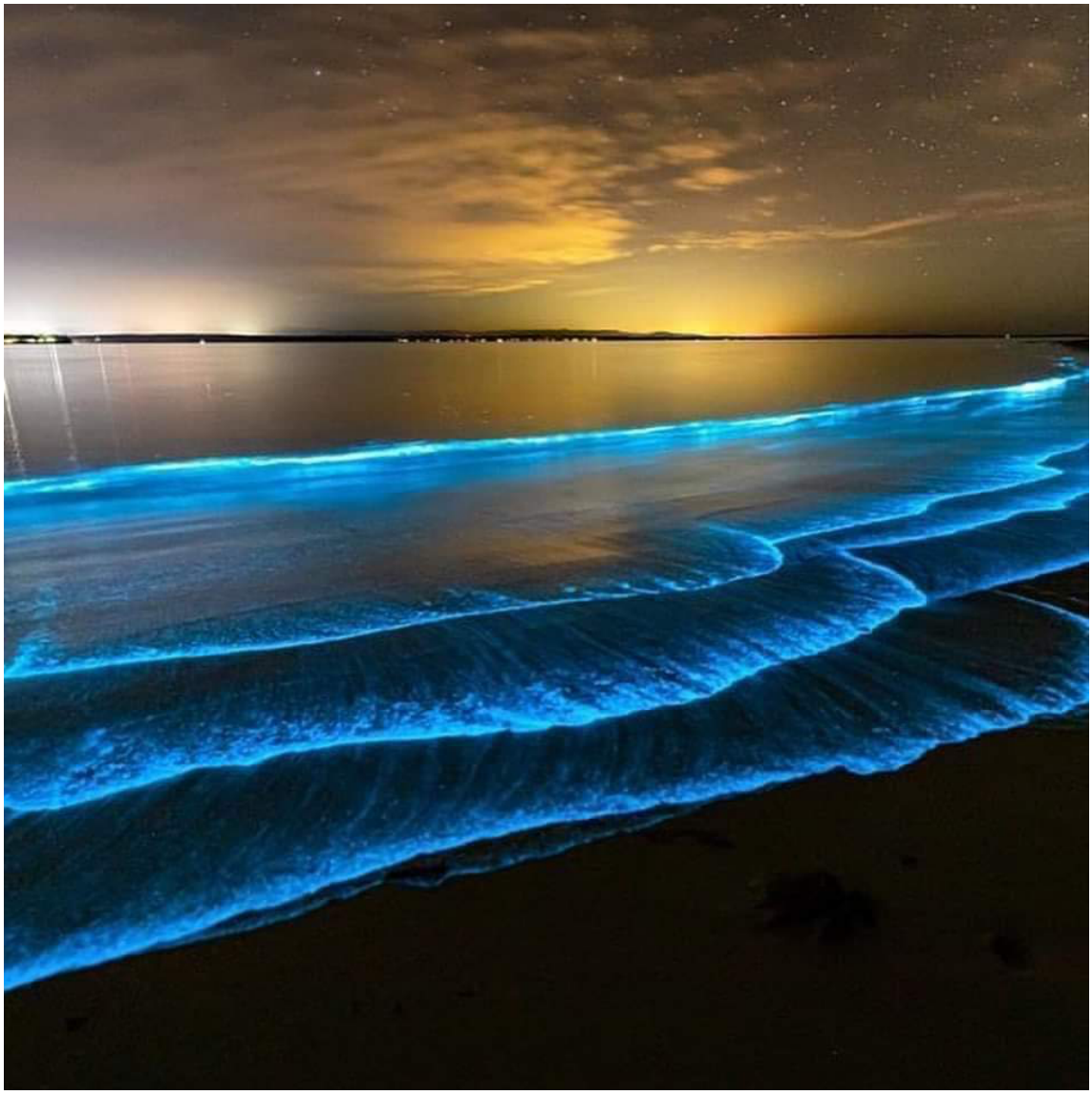
First Congregational Church
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 10
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Flow

8 November 2026



The bioluminescence in Imperial Beach, California. Photo by Robert Brianss

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Improvisation on DIX and BUNESSAN
Mina/Dracula from *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (Wojciech Kilar)
KING'S WESTON (Anthony Giamanco)
ZEUCH MICH, ZEUCH MICH (Paul Fejko)
For the Beauty of the Earth (Margaretha Christina de Jong)
Toccata in C Major (Jan Pieterszoon Sweelinck) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome **Rev. Michael Lehman**

Words of Gathering **Rev. Lehman & Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz**

Celtic wisdom looks for the flow of the divine
deep within everything that has being.
It is like a subterranean river coursing
through the veins of the universe.
If somehow it were dammed up or stopped,
everything would cease to exist.

This sacred flow is not simply a dimension of life
that may or may not be there,
depending on the moment, the place,
the person, or the species.
It is the very essence of everything that exists.

On this day, let us awaken and look for the flow
of the Divine deepen within all things
and then, release it to ourselves
and one another. [jphilipnewell]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

Hymn of Gathering** ***For the Beauty of the Earth DIX

For the beauty of the earth, for the splendor of the skies,
For the love which from our birth over and around us lies,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the wonder of each hour of the day and of the night,
Hill and vale, and tree and flower, sun and moon, and stars of light,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the joy of human love, brother, sister, parent, child,
Friends on earth, and friends above, for all gentle thoughts and mild,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

For the good that love inspires, for a world where none exclude,
For a faith that never tires, and for every heart renewed,
God of all, to you we raise this our hymn of grateful praise.

***Prayer of Awareness** **Rev. Lehman**

Holy One, in this sacred space, we bind unto ourselves today -
the virtues of the star-lit heaven, the glorious sun's life-giving rays,
the whiteness of the moon at even, the flashing of the lightning free,
the whirling winds tempestuous shocks, the stable earth, the deep salt sea
around the old eternal rocks.
Help us in this time to weave together
spirit and matter as we seek the Divine
around us, among us, and within us.

[adapted from The Prayer of St. Patrick hymn]

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit** The Light of a Clear Blue Morning DOLLY PARTON

I can see the light of a clear blue morning. Everything's gonna work out fine.
Everything's gonna be alright. It's gonna be OK.

***The Lord's Prayer** **Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz**

Eternal Spirit
Life Giver, Pain Bearer, Love-Maker;
Source of all that is and that shall be;
Father and Mother of us all;
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name
echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.

With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.

For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,
now and forever. Amen.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace** **Rev. Lehman**

All things come from you, O God,
and to you we return.
All things emerge in your great river of life
and into you we vanish again.
At the beginning of this day
we wake
not as separate streams
but as countless currents in a single flow
the flow of this day's dawning
the flow of this day's delight
the flow of this day's sorrows
your flow, O God,
in the twistings and turnings of our days.
[jphilipnewell]

This morning, within all that is, and all that will be,
May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition **Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz**

from the Gospel of Mark

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People **Rev. Lehman**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

It is in the depths of life that we find you, Holy One.
At this heart of this moment
at the center of our soul
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.
You are the Ground of all being
the Well-Spring of time
womb of earth
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait
not for blessings from afar
but for You
the very Soil of our soul
the early Freshness of morning.
Time and eternity intertwined, heaven and earth inseparably
woven together, the sacred flowing deep in the matter earth
and the human mystery. [jphilipnewell]

May it ever be so.
May it always be so for us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem Whispering Waters KEITH CHRISTOPHER
Esme Gregoropoulos, *Violin,* Dr. Bull, *Piano,* Cathedral Choir
Be still and hear the whispering waters. The waters flow so freely and know us by name.

Sermon ***Sacred Flow*** **Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

The Eucharist and Blessings **Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman**

Invitation to Communion & Words of Remembrance
God of all creation,
from before there was a beginning,
until after there is an end,
you were and are and always will be.
All creation is alive
in you, and with you, and beside you.
For everything that is, came into being through you.

In praise and thanksgiving,
with leaves that whisper,
brooks that babble,
with birds of the air and the fish of the sea,
and the stars above…
We join with all creation in saying,
Thanks be to you, O God.

As those who long to follow the Way of Jesus,
and with those who live other paths,
We celebrate Life!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup
At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity **Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz**

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory Bridge Over Troubled Water WORDS AND MUSIC: PAUL SIMON

Frank Hobbs, *Tenor,* Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer** **Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz**

Holy One, as your life flows through the rivers and streams of this earth,
remind us on this day, that your life also flows through us.
With these offerings we offer our thanks and praise
and ask that the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness
to move freely in our words and actions.
Awaken in us, the possibility of new life, new vision,
and renewed meaning and purpose
as we follow in the steps of those
whose faith continues to flow
around us, among us, and within us.

Thanks be to you, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church **Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin**

Words of Blessing **Rev. Fregin**

May the deep blessings of earth be with us.
May the fathomless soundings of seas surge in souls.
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths
to open us to wonder
to strengthen us for love
to humble us with gratitude

that we may find ourselves in one another
that we may lose ourselves in gladness
that we may give ourselves to peace.

Choral Response Bridge Over Troubled Water - *Choral Reprise* WORDS AND MUSIC: PAUL SIMON

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

Hymn for the Journey** ***Come, See the Fullness BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open our hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

Postlude **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Postlude in Bb Major (Paul Fejko)

Inside The Music

"In the Celtic theological notion of *Sacred Flow* we revere waters as part of the Divine Feminine—that through the powers of waters which live and breathe, we find restorative forces which connect us as cosmic arteries to the source of all being. Perhaps you have felt in your own lives a moment when breathing near water has brought you peace, or a sense of *deep knowing*. This deep knowledge is our connection to that sacred flow which runs within us, between us, and connects us all.

In our musical exploration today we sing of those forces. First, in the Dolly Parton anthem *Light of a Clear Blue Morning*, feeling the wave of hope pass through us as we continue the work towards building systems that work for justice and dignity for all. Then, in the Keith Christopher anthem *Whispering Waters*, whose poetry and music illustrate that if we are still, we can hear the waters who call to us, and who know us by name. Poetry is in motion through vocalization in the choir which turns the vocal instrument into living breathing waves, and through solo movement of the Violin, played today by one of our beloved Youth, Esme Gregoropoulos. In her line, we hear the lilting movement of water in sighing eighth note patterns borrowed from the Baroque era—a rhetorical device used to signify the motion of emotion.

In offertory, Frank and Christoph bring us the classic by Paul Simon, *Bridge Over Troubled Water*, a reminder in this time that while the flow is sacred, she is not always smooth. As in the scripture reading today from the Gospel according to Mark, there will be *fierce gales which swamp,* but through those moments which are also sacred, we have one another. In benediction, we have a full choral reprise of this message, acting as a call and response between us all: *I will be your bridge*, and so will *we for you*. In what Dr. King called *the beloved community*, we move together with and for one another in her ebb and sacred flow."

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